nourishes me, the smell of African soil.

Every minute spent in the bush is a blessing.

When I was young, we used to visit the Kruger Park as a family. We would stay in a rondavel in one of the camps, and drive around the park in a Volkswagen camper van, looking for animals. As the youngest brother eager to prove myself, I found it almost impossible to resist the temptation of triumphantly declaring I had spotted, say, a lion or a buffalo, when in fact I hadn't seen anything. I think I was quite irritating.

I am not so crazy about game drives these days. For me, the greatest pleasure lies in just being in the bush, just enjoying the environment, just being there, feeling close to nature and feeling close to God; and, of course, the entire experience improves dramatically when your cellphone can't pick up a signal.

In recent years, I have invested in exotic wildlife with my father-in-law, John Swart. We bought some sables and we keep them at a place called Shakama, north of Bela-Bela. The investment works well but it is emotionally even more rewarding to watch these remarkable animals grow and to see the herd multiply.

'A World in One Country' was the promotional line used by South African Tourism a few years ago, and they weren't wrong if you consider that, beyond the bush and game parks, South Africa offers coastal cities such as Cape Town and Durban, miles of beautiful beaches, the winelands, the Garden Route, the Drakensberg and much more.

I have got to know the country as a cricketer, not as a tourist.

Pretoria may not be the first place on every visitor's itinerary, but it should not be missed. It's relaxed and calm, and when the jacaranda trees blossom in September and October it puts its best foot forward. From a cricketing point of view, SuperSport Park is my favourite ground in the country.

It's where, in 1995, I watched the Proteas for the first time. It's where my father bought me the Jonty Rhodes cap, which became the most